

BACTRIAN CAMEL

Camelus bactrianus

The Bactrian camel is an exceptionally hardy animal, built to survive in the harsh desert landscapes of southern Asia, where temperatures range between 40°C (104°F) in summer and -29°C (-20°F) in winter. Camels are adapted to travel long distances over difficult terrain in search of food – such as grasses, leaves, and shrubs – which is scarce. When water is available, the Bactrian camel is able to gulp more than 100 litres (26 gallons) in 10 minutes. It can also survive by drinking salty water if necessary. Almost all of the world's Bactrian camels are domesticated; fewer than 1,000 animals remain in the wild, in remote and inhospitable parts of China and Mongolia. While the genetic status of the two domestic species of camel has long been established, the wild two-humped camel has only recently been recognized as a separate species, *Camelus ferus*, based on molecular genetic data.

closeable nostrils
keep sand out

small, furry
ears

thick fur keeps the
camel warm, and
also protects it
from sunburn

✓ EYELASHES

Two rows of extra-thick eyelashes protect the eyes from strong sunlight, and windblown sand and grit, saving precious water from being blinked away as tears.

✓ KNEE PADS

Camels rest on their knees, with their legs folded beneath them. The knees are protected by thick pads of skin.

shaggy mane

SIZE 1.8–2 m (6–6½ ft)
HABITAT Stony desert, steppe, and rocky plains
DISTRIBUTION Asia
DIET Herbivorous

^ TEETH

Camels swallow their food whole, then regurgitate and rechew it to aid digestion. Starving individuals have been known to eat rope and leather, which are hard to break down.

^ MOBILE LIPS

Each half of the split upper lip can be controlled independently, which probably helps them browse thorny vegetation effectively without using their tongues and, thereby, losing moisture.

< ^ FEET

The feet each have two toes and a tough padded sole that allows the camel to cope equally well with sharp stony ground, hot sand, or compacted snow.

